Topic 1: Pre-16th Century Philippines Reading Materials

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INTRODUCTION FOR PRE-16TH CENTURY READINGS

Jose Rhommel B. Hernandez, Ph.D.

The following are ten readings discussing certain aspects of the Pre-16th Century Philippines. The excerpts are discussions of archaeological and historical studies on particular topics concerning the Philippines. The first excerpt is from the article of archaeologists Armand Salvador Mijares and his team discussing the initial finds in Callao Cave in Peñablanca, Cagayan. These findings would later on be the foundations in establishing the human remains as the *Homo luzonensis.* This is currently acknowledged as a species of Homo and thus establishing the Philippines as a part of the archaeological map of human evolution.

The second excerpt is from the article of archaeologist Eusebio Dizon and his team on the human remains from the Tabon Cave in Palawan. Discovered in the 1960s by the archaeologist Robert Fox, Dizon and his team went further in reassessing the area resulting in new dates and eleven more human remains. The readings three, four and five are from the study of Peter Bellwood and company regarding the Austronesians. The excerpts study different aspects of the migration and settlement of the Austronesian in the Philippines and Southeast Asia. Included also are the Pacific Islands and Madagascar near the African Coast.

Reading Sixth is from the work of archaeologist Alfredo E. Evangelista providing a glimpse on the life of ancient Filipinos based on the so-called "soul boats." These "soul boats" are actually wooden coffins shaped like boats and are found in different archaeological sites in the Philippines. At around the same time of these "soul boats" is the document written by a Chinese bureaucrat named Chao Ju-Kua. The document is provided herein as Reading number 7 detailing some contacts made by the author with the peoples of Ma-yi which archaeologists and historians recognize as either Manila or Mindoro.

Readings eight and nine are studies dealing with methodological problems in the field of Philippine Prehistory. Reading eight is from the lecture of F. Landa Jocano on the different problems in the study of Philippine Prehistory while Reading nine is from the study of historian William Henry Scott on the Maragtas. Reading ten is a transcript of a story regarding the first people of Sulu. Mythical at most but it shows the understanding of a group of people regarding their past.

"A New Species of Homo in the Late Pleistocene of the Philippines"

This is an excerpt of the seminal article on the discoveries made by archaeologist Armand Salvador Mijares and his team (Florent Detroit, Philip Piper, Rainier Grun, Peter Bellwood, Maxime Aubert, Guillaume Champion, Nida Cuevas, Alexandra De Leon, Eusebio Dizon) in the Callao Cave in Peñablanca, Cagayan. This particular study details the discovery of the Right Metatarsal 3 (RMT3) of a human being in Callao Cave, Cagayan. Now designated as the *Homo luzonensis*, the date of the said remains is 67,000 years Before Present. Comparisons were made with the other human remains found in Southeast Asia.

Excerpt:

Hominin movement into Island Southeast Asia has always been problematic due to the lack of well-dated human remains. The humid tropical environment of Island Southeast Asia contributes to the problems of bone preservation. Early modern human remains have, however, been recovered in Niah Cave in Sarawak, Malaysian Borneo, dating to 42 ka, and from Tabon Cave in Palawan dating to 47 plus/minus 10/11 ka. Borneo is located on the sunda shelf and was possibly joined by dry land to Sumatra, Java and Peninsular Malaysia during periods of lowered sea level in the Pleistocene. The island of Palawan may have been intermittently attached to northeastern Borneo when sea levels reached their minima during the most extreme climatic phases. Thus, migrating human populations could have reached both islands without necessarily requiring a sea crossing.

To reach the rest of the Philippine archipelago and other islands in the Wallacean group (e.g., Sulawesi, Flores, Timor) that were never attached to either mainland Asia or Australasia (Sahul), open sea crossings were required. The Lake Mungo remains from Australia dating to 40 plus/minus 2 ka are evidence that modern humans were capable of making early sea crossings.

Homo floresiensis, discovered on the islands of Flores, Indonesia, is another hominin that managed to cross the Wallace line. While its remains are only dated to 18-38 ka, Flores also has stone artifact assemblages suggesting that a hominin of unknown affinity reached the island more than 800 ka years ago. Our recent excavations (2007) in Callao Cave have produced what is probably one of the earliest hominin fossils east of Wallace's Line, from the island of Luzon, northern Philippines.

The Callao Cave metatarsal indicates that species of hominin crossed water gaps between Sundaland and Wallacea to reach northern Luzon by 67,000 years ago. The specimen leaves us with a conundrum—in size, it compares with modern Negrito populations, but a few morphological features are unusual. A comprehensive analysis of size and shape characteristics, including comparisons with larger samples of *Homo sapiens* and fossil species of the genus *Homo*, is now needed.

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Provisionally attributed to a rather small-bodied Homo sapiens, the Callao MT3 documents the presence of a hominin species on the island of Luzon as early as 67 ka, and is testimony to a capability to colonize new territories across open sea gaps. The Philippine specimen also indicates that Flores was not the only island in Wallacea to be occupied by hominins more than 50,000 years ago.

The discoveries of Callao Cave also raise some other important questions about the cultural behavior of these early colonizers of the Philippine Archipelago. For example, even though there is evidence of butchery in the animal bone assemblage, not a single stone implement was recovered, suggesting perhaps the use of an alternative technology. To answer such questions, more archaeological research in the cavies of karstic limestone formations of the Philippines is required.

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"Upper Pleistocene Homo sapiens From the Tabon Cave (Palawan, The Philippines): Description and Dating of New Discoveries"

The following is an excerpt of a collaborative study between Filipino and French scholars on the much discussed and cited human remains of the so-called Tabon Man. The original discovery was made in the 1960s by the archaeologist Robert Fox. The authors of the study Upper Pleistocene Homo sapiens from the Tabon cave (Palawan, The Philippines): description and dating of new discoveries are Florent Detroit (French), Eusebio Dizon (Filipino), Christophe Falgueres (French), Sebastien Hameau (French), Wilfredo Ronquillo (Filipino) and Francois Semah (French). The study reassessed the discoveries made by Fox in the 1960s and resulted to new dates and yielded eleven more human remains. The original article was published by Science Direct in 2004 under the category Human

Paleontology and Prehistory.

Excerpt:

The Tabon Cave is located in the southwest coast of the Palawan Island. The site has been thoroughly studied in the 1960s by Robert Fox from the National Museum of the Philippines.

Owing to the discovery of long-lasting human occupation layers, abundant lithic industries and human fossils, the Tabon Cave is frequently quoted as one of the most important upper Pleistocene sites from insular Southeast Asia. Indeed, it is worth noting that the human fossil record of this large geographical are still suffers a major gap corresponding approximately to the Upper Pleistocene period. Thus, the Tabon human fossils are among the very scarce specimens that could candidate to stand chronologically between the latest Indonesian Homo erectus (such as Solo Man) and the earlies Homo sapiens from insular Southeast Asia. The age of the former group is still highly disputed, from more than 100,000 to least that 50,000 years BP, whereas the oldest anatomically modern Homo sapiens known up to now only date back to the very late Upper Pleistocene and Early Holocene period.

Despite their high significance, the human remains recovered from the Tabon Cave had not been described and published after their discovery. Nor there have been attempts to answer the numerous questions arising from the R. Fox's pioneering work until recent fieldwork was undertaken by the Archaeological Division of the National Museum of the Philippines.

A scientific collaboration between this institution and the Prehistory Department of the *Museum national d'Histoire naturelle* (Paris) resulted as a first step in the exhaustive paleoanthropological description of these historical human fossil finds and direct dating of the Tabon frontal bone.

All the human fossils recovered from the Tabon cave, including the early discoveries of the 1960s show a similar aspect (reddish-brown color of the bones and abundant concretions on the bone surface) that indicates that they probably underwent several fossilization processes.

Only a robust mandibular fragment from the earlier excavations appears to be considerably more mineralized than the other fossils.

From the whole human fossil record, two specimens obviously differ from others. These are respectively the very robust mandibular fragment and the immature partial atlas. All other specimens (frontal bone, mandibular fragment, ulna epiphysis, tibia diaphysis, fragments of fibula, partial calcaneus, metatarsal, proximal phalange and lumbar vertebra) show medium to small proportions and morphological features that correspond to an overall weakly built anatomically modern Homo sapiens. Therefore, it seems possible that they belonged to a single individual and from a strictly anatomical point of view, the minimal number of human individuals is 3 for the Tabon cave. However, the dating results, pointing to a discrepancy between the frontal bone, one of the fragmentary mandible and the tibia indicate a probable higher number of individuals.

Questions arising from these new discoveries deal with the relationships that could be traced between the specimens of the fossil record. From a biological point of view, one may ask whether the fossils unearthed represent one or more prehistoric human groups and, in a broader perspective, what are their phylogenetic relationship with other fossil Homo sapiens known from insular Southeast Asian sites such as Niah (Borneo), Moh Khiew (peninsular Thailand) and the Gunung Sequ are (East Java).

The association of specimens exhibiting respectively large and small overall dimensions points to the presence of at least two distinct Homo sapiens morphologies in the Tabon Cave during the Upper Pleistocene times. I t could be the result of a taphonomic association of two actually distinct groups of Homo sapiens (biologically and or/chronologically) or only reflect the presence of a single group characterized by a high sexual dimorphism. However, the former hypothesis seems currently more likely. The unnumbered left mandibular fragment shows an obviously more primitive overall morphology than any other individuals (large dimensions associated with a series of primitive morphological features). And, as a first impression, the pattern of association of morphological features documented by other specimens indicates to some extent affinities with Australian fossil Homo sapiens. For instance, the conspicuous morphology of the supra-orbital complex of the frontal bone, which combines projecting glabella and supraciliary arches with rather thin and clearly separated lateral trigones.

"The Austronesians: Historical and Comparative Perspective"

This is an excerpt of The Austronesians in History: Common Origins and Diverse Transformations from the book edited by Peter Bellwood, The Austronesians: Historical and Comparative Perspectives (2006). It gives a general background on the Austronesian expansion. The Austronesians is a linguistic group recognized as the immediate ancestors of Filipinos as well as other Southeast Asians. Bellwood, a British Archaeologist who was educated in Cambridge and is one of the leading experts on the subject, effectively summarized in this brief excerpt the basic information on the expansion of different Austronesian groups from Easter Island near Chile in South America until Madagascar.

Excerpt:

It is necessary to return again to the linguistic evidence in order to plot the geographical axes of expansion of early An-speaking peoples. Beginning with Pre-Austronesian level, a number of claims have been made for Asian genetic relationships between An and other Asian mainland language families. Perhaps the best known of these claims is the Austro-Thai hypothesis of Paul Benedict (1975; Reid 1984-5), which postulates that the Tai-Kadai and Austronesian language or chain of languages spoken on the southern Chinese mainland. Benedict has suggested a number of important vocabulary reconstructions for this ancestral language, including terms for field, wet-field (for rice or taro), garden, rice, sugarcane, cattle, water buffalo, axe and canoe. The overlap between this list and that presented above for Hemudu and other coastal southern Chinese Neolithic sites needs little emphasis. One has to consider very seriously the possibility that the initial expansions of Austronesians and TaiKadai languages (and probably also Austroasiaic) began among Neleolithic rice-cultivating communities in China south of the Yangzi. The archeological record agrees very well and provides a date range for initial developments between 5000-4000 BC.

Moving beyond Austro-Tai into Austronesian proper, the reconstruction of linguistic prehistory which is most widely used today is that postulated by Robert Blust (1884-5). This is based on a "family-tree" of subgroups and a hierarchy of proto-languages extending from Proto Austronesian (Pan) forwards in time. Reduced to its essentials, Blust's reconstruction favors a geographical expansion beginning in Taiwan (the location of the oldest Austronesian languages including Pan), then encompassing the Philippines, Borneo and Sulawesi, and finally bifurcating, one branch moving west to Java, Sumatra and Malaya, the other moving east into Oceania (see Darrell Tyron's more detailed summary in this volume).

A wealth of linguistic detail can be added to this framework but here I will restrict myself to some implications of broad historical and cultural significance. During the linguistic stage before the break up of Pan it would appear that some colonies with an agricultural

economy moved across the Formosa Strait to the Chinese mainland to Taiwan (Mainland 19845, 1992). Here developed the Austronesian languages (s), and after a few centuries some of these languages made the first moves into Luzon and the Philippines. This movement led to the division of Austronesian into its two major subgroups, Formosan and Malayo-Polynesian (or Extra-Formosan). The reconstructed Pan vocabulary, which relates generally to this early Taiwan-Luzon phase, indicates an economy we;; suited for marginal tropical latitudes with cultivation of rice, millet, sugarcane, domestication of dogs and pigs, and the use of some kind of watercraft.

As a result of further colonizing movements through the Philippines into Borneo, Sulawesi and the Moluccas, the Malayo-Polynesian (MP) subgroup eventually separated into its several lower-order Western and Central-Eastern branches. The break-up of Central-Eastern MP probably occurred initially in the Moluccas, and Eastern MP contains all the Austronesian languages of the Pacific Islands apart from some in western Micronesia. The vocabulary of Proto-Malayo-Polynesia (PMP), a linguistic entity which might have been located somewhere in the Philippines, is of great interest because it contains a number of tropical economic indicators which were absent in the earlier and more northerly Pan stage. These include, according to Blust (1984-5), Colocosia taro, breadfruit, banana, yam, sago and coconut. Their presences may reflect a shift away from rice, a plant initially adapted to sub-tropical latitudes, towards a greater dependence on tubers and fruits in equatorial latitudes (Bellwood 1980a, 1985). The PMP vocabulary also has terms for pottery, sailing canoes and several components of substantial houses (Zorc 1994).

It may now be asked how the archeological record relates to this reconstruction of the directions and cultural components of Austronesian expansion. Specific archeological cultures cannot logically be equated with specific ancestral languages in prehistoric time. However, the appearance of certain technological and economic components of Pan and PMP can be searched for profitably in the archeological record of the area now occupied by Austronesian speakers. As already indicated, it is a reasonable inference that both Pan and PMP represent agricultural societies who, amongst other things, grew rice, made pots, lived in well-made timber houses and kept domesticated pigs. As it happens, direct material evidence of all these items survives in the archeological records of the islands of Southeast Asia, and all of them make an initial appearance in widespread excavated sites between about 4000 and 1500 BC. Furthermore, their appearances (especially pottery) show a time trend – earliest in the northerly regions of China, Taiwan and Luzon and progressively later as one moves southwards into equatorial Indonesia and western Oceania (Springs 1989). Given this seeming correlation between the linguistic and archeological records (Bellwood 1985), we may hypothesize a direct association with the dispersal of the Austronesian language speakers, rather that dispersal of the cultural items by diffusion alone.